versions of all this, such as PayPal.) If allowed to develop, I foresaw that it would permit small activist groups who were in danger of being surveilled to resist government coercion. That was the hope, anyway. That was the plan and the dream. But many of the brilliant minds of my generation of cypherpunks floated off in the dot com bubble. They became obsessed with stock options and Palm Pilots and lost the urge for real change.

Digging down into our cypherpunk mindsets, we saw that one of the great battles – our Spanish Civil War, if you like – was going to be about how we served in the effort to defend the world against the surveillance of private computer networks. Issues of freedom and the fight against oppression were located there, as surely as they once were in the hills of Catalonia, and we wanted to zip up and go out and fight the good fight against police statehood as best we could. We were idealistic, of course, and young: the usual condition of people wanting to make a difference. We would make mistakes and we would be punished for them. We also might never gain the sense of possibility again that we had among ourselves. That is life's risk, almost life's certainty, though we set out nonetheless.

The issue of privacy would always haunt me. It haunts me now. At WikiLeaks, I would come to seem the arch-proponent of transparency, forever described as the man who thinks all privacy is bad. But it was never my position that all privacy is bad: rather the opposite. We fought, as cypherpunks, to protect people's privacy. What I opposed, and continue to oppose, is the use of secrecy by institutions to protect themselves against the truth of the evil they have done. This is a clear distinction. Even in this book, where I try to tell my story as best I can, there will be moments of privacy, because I owe it to some greater sense of justice, to my children, for example, not to drag them into the limelight. Some people, in love with a category error, will wish to hold me to account on this score, as if the founder of WikiLeaks must, out of some bogus sense of consistency, blow the whistle on every element of his private self.

I will not indulge that fantasy. I will not play that game. Yet I will try to open up about all the matters that truly matter. I say this, because at the time I have reached in this account of my life, I had a child with the woman I was going out with and living with. The child is Daniel. He is a good man, and I have tried to be a capable father to him. We had him young and his mother and I were later in dispute, for a long time, about how he should be cared for, but that is all there is to it. It was a difficult time, there was a